

Introduction to the Digital Research Alliance of Canada

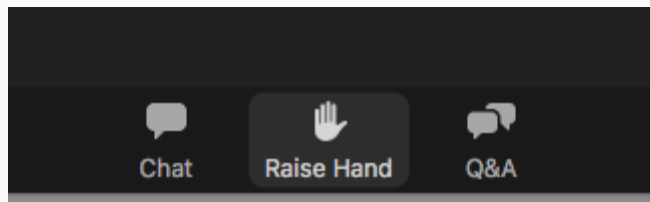
Humanities & Social Sciences training series, 2026-27
September 22nd, 2026



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada

Housekeeping • *Rappels logistiques.*



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada

Code of Conduct.

Code de conduite.



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada

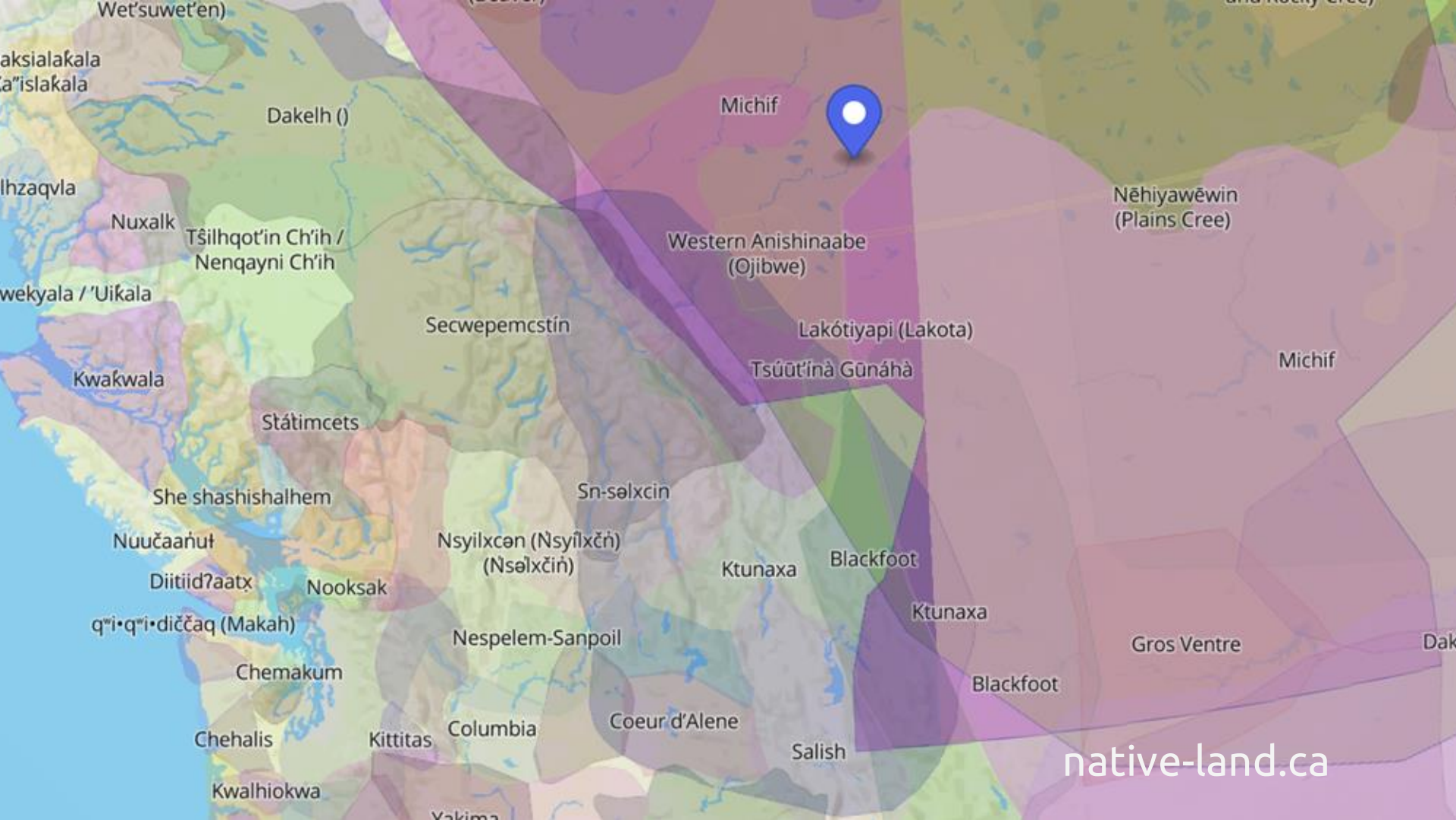
Land Acknowledgement.

Reconnaissance du territoire.



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada



Introduction to the Digital Research Alliance of Canada

Humanities & Social Sciences training series, 2026-27
September 22nd, 2026



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada

Presentation outline.

In this quick introduction, we will go over the following:

- The Digital Research Alliance of Canada & Canada's Advanced Research Computing Platform
 - Accessing the Alliance's resources
- Advanced research computing
 - High-performance computing
 - Cloud computing
- Getting computing support
 - HSS-specific resources



**Digital Research
Alliance of Canada**

**Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada**

Digital Research Alliance of Canada.

The [Digital Research Alliance of Canada](#) is a non-profit organization, funded by the federal government, that coordinates and co-funds digital research infrastructure (DRI) to support Canadian researchers, specifically in the areas of:

- Advanced research computing (ARC)
- Research data management (RDM)
- Research software (RS)



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada

Advanced Research Computing.

Advanced research computing (ARC) is any computing for research purposes that requires more than just your personal computer to do.

Researchers from all disciplines use ARC to accelerate and power up their research. These kinds of computational and data-intensive research rely on high-speed networks, powerful high-performance computing systems, secure storage options and effective support.

ARC in HSS can look like running online surveys, analysing large amounts of text, generating maps and visualizations, and hosting public facing websites for knowledge mobilization (and more!).

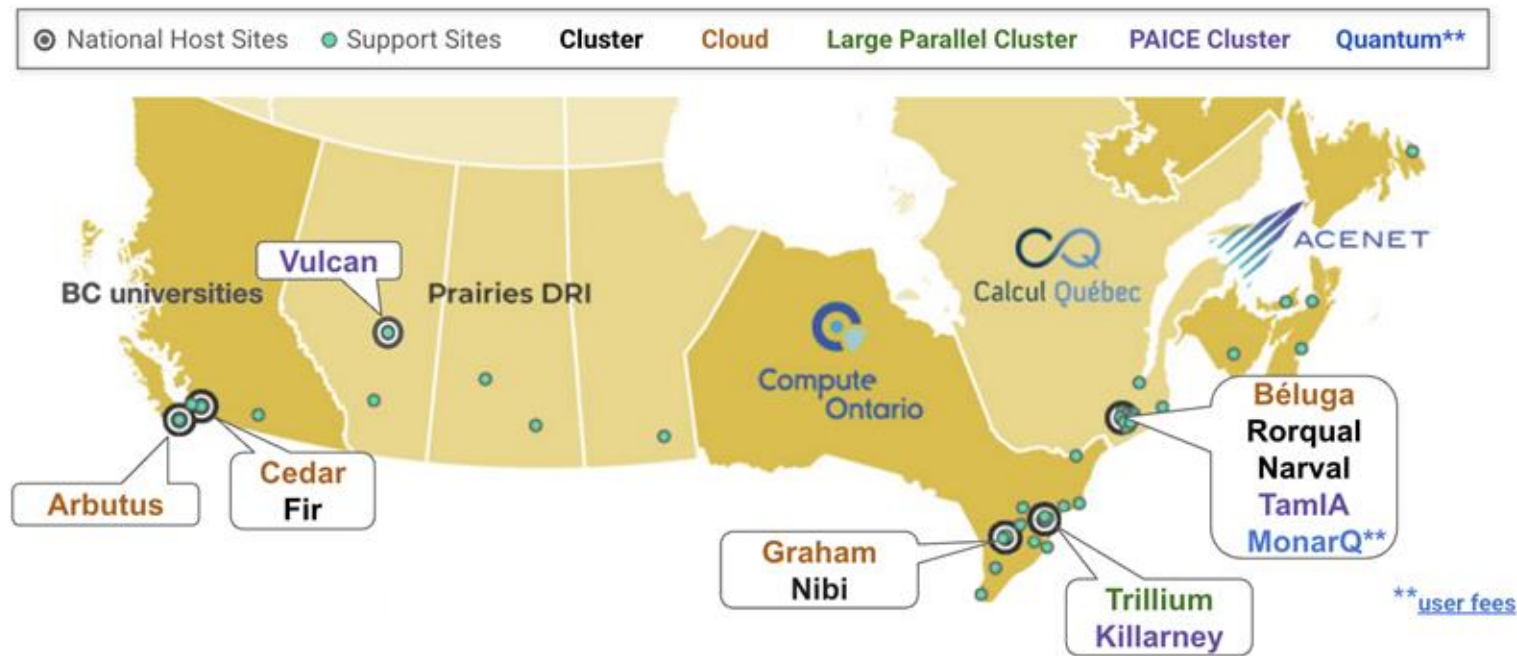
The Alliance supports ARC through both infrastructure and researcher support.



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada

Canada's Advanced Research Computing Platform.



Accessing Alliance resources.



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada

English || [Français](#)

[Home](#) | [Support](#) ▾

Welcome to the CCDB, your gateway to account, usage, and allocation information for the Advanced Research Computing platform provided by the Digital Research Alliance of Canada (the Alliance) with its regional partners BC DRI Group, Prairies DRI Group, Compute Ontario, Calcul Québec and ACENET.

In order to access our computational resources, users must register with the CCDB. Visit this [page](#) for more information about our accounts.

Please sign in

Login:

You can use your email address, CCI, CCRI or username to log in.

Password:

[Sign in](#)

|| [Forgot Password](#) || [Register](#)

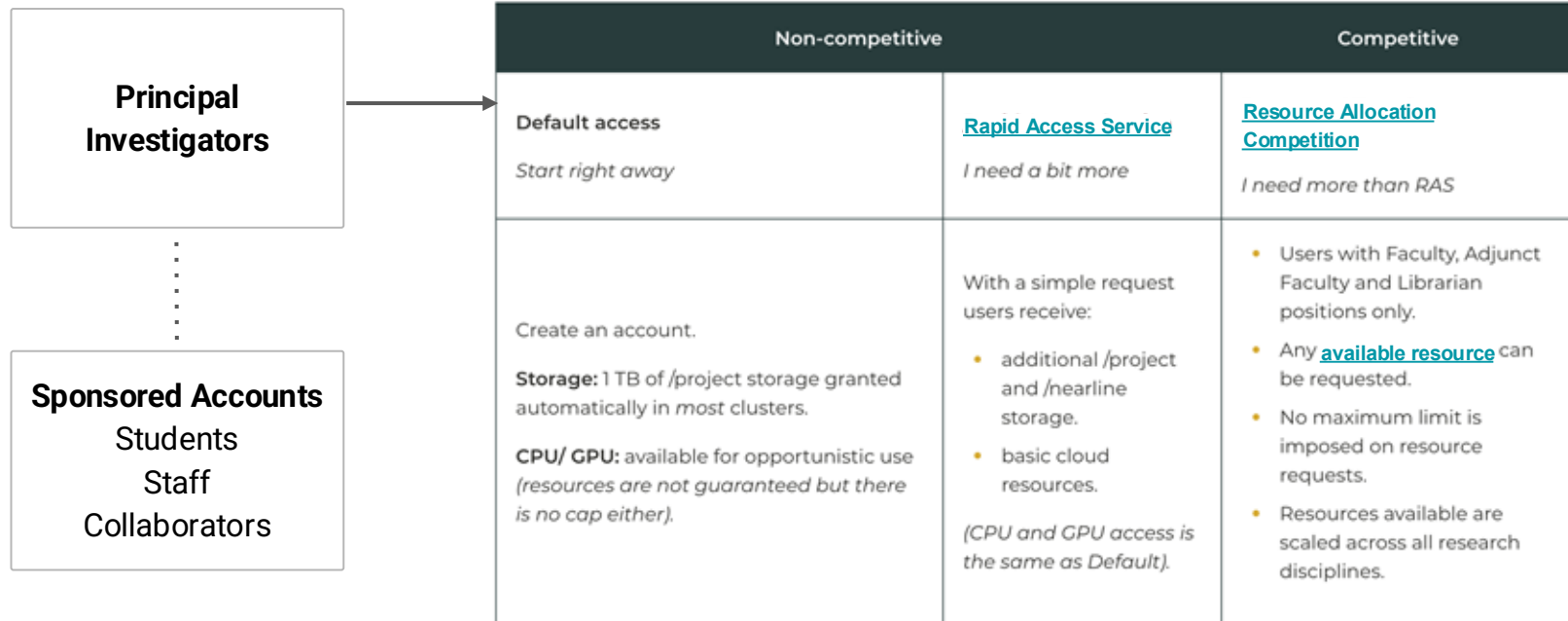
© 2008-2025 [Digital Research Alliance of Canada](#) || [email Support](#)



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada

Accessing Alliance resources.



High-performance computing.

High-performance computing (HPC) is also known as supercomputing. It can handle:

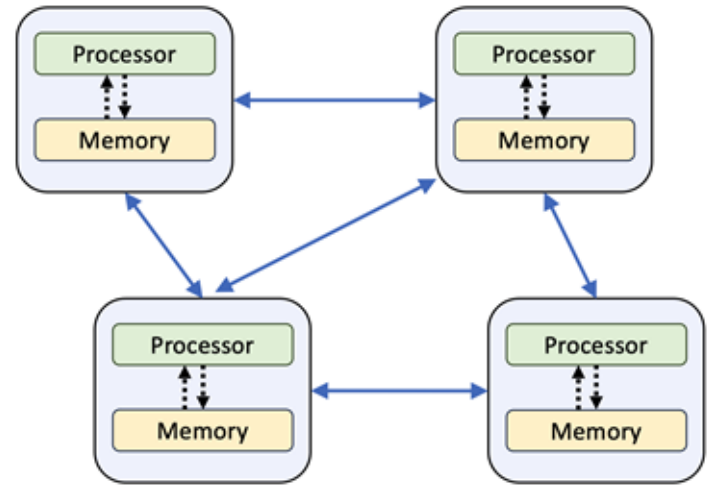
- Faster computation
- Larger problem
- More detailed simulations

HPC involves many cores working together, which can mean:

- Many single core jobs running at the same time, or
- Many cores working in sync to solve the same problem

Either way, communication between cores is key!

Principle tool for HPC is the computing cluster.



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada

High-performance computing.



Personal computer



CPU



Fir supercomputer, Simon Fraser University, BC

Video about the new Fir cluster (2025):

<https://youtu.be/U4Sqh-uJ2NA>



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada

Dr. Ethan Fosse, Associate Professor of Sociology, University of Toronto

“We use the Digital Research Alliance of Canada's high-performance computing systems to examine how public discourse changes over time in large text data. Our current project analyzes newspaper coverage to identify how topics emerge, persist, split, and transform across periods, with the goal of understanding changing patterns of meaning. In doing so, we develop a novel unsupervised learning method for analyzing how meaning changes in text data, which contrasts with conventional methods, such as topic modeling, that assume meaning is time-invariant. This is sociologically important because it helps reveal how institutions classify the social world, how issue attention rises and falls, and how cultural and political boundaries are reproduced or reworked in public communication. High-performance computing makes our analysis possible by allowing us to run computationally intensive language models repeatedly across many temporal slices, compare alternative specifications, and work at a scale that matches the scope of the substantive questions. Our computational pipeline could be used to analyze a number of other important questions, such as those related to shifting narratives around inequality, polarization, migration, trust, health crises, or social movements.”



**Digital Research
Alliance of Canada**

**Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada**

Cloud computing.

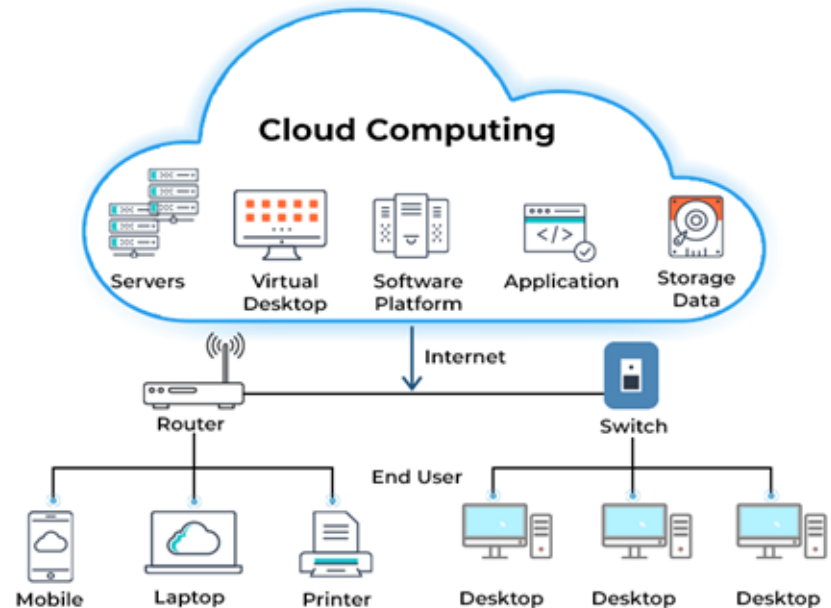
Cloud computing is basically a pool of hardware that supports virtual versions of physical computers.

Cloud computing can be used in a variety of ways, including:

- Web-hosting
- Bursts of on-demand computing

HPC is better for powerful computing, cloud for always-available computing.

Most common way to use the cloud is with a virtual machine.



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada



Dr. Susan Brown, Department of English, University of Guelph

Project: Canadian Writing Research Collaboratory (CWRC)

Supports a number of humanities research projects through a hosting environment featuring tools that allow researchers to work collaboratively with different types of materials and resources, such as XML documents, bibliographic records, multimedia objects, or linked open data (LOD).



Storage options.

The Alliance offers a variety of storage options on their clusters, including:

- Project, scratch, nearline, object

Default allocations for each option vary across the clusters, and you can find specifics in the [Alliance's online documentation](#).

The Alliance's data storage options are appropriate for all but the most sensitive data or certain proprietary data. All data stored on the Alliance's systems are physically in Canada.

The Alliance holds a subscription to [Globus](#), a tool for reliable, fast, and secure data transfers.



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada

HSS specific resources.

- The Alliance includes a [national HSS team](#)
 - You can reach us by emailing support@tech.alliancecan.ca with “HSS” in the subject line
- [HSS Spotlight Webinar Series](#) on digital and computational research in the humanities and social sciences
- WestDRI (SFU) [video archive](#) of training
- Connect with other social science and humanities researchers and experts through the [HSS Commons](#)
- Find more digital humanities workshops through the [Canadian Certificate in Digital Humanities/Humanités Numériques](#)



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada

HSS training series, 2026-27.

- 9 workshops between October 2026 and March 2027 covering the following topics for HSS audiences:
 - Endings compliance for digital projects
 - Introduction to cloud computing
 - Ollama, OpenRefine, ChainForge
 - R and Python
 - Depositing data

[Visit the series site for more information and to register](#)



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada

cc:DH N CANADIAN CERTIFICATE IN DIGITAL HUMANITIES CERTIFICAT CANADIEN EN HUMANITÉS NUMÉRIQUES

This workshop is eligible to count towards the Canadian Certificate for Digital Humanities (cc:DH/HN). If you're interested in learning more about the certificate, visit <https://ccdhhn.ca/>.

Cet atelier est admissible au Certificat Canadien en Humanités Numériques (cc:DH/HN). Si vous souhaitez en savoir plus sur le certificat, visitez <https://ccdhhn.ca/fr/>.

How do you earn a certificate?



CCDHHN.CA

- 100 hours of DH workshops (not for course credit)
- 60 hours completed in Canada
- 60 hours in-depth workshops (20 hours+ each)
- 5-year timespan
- maximum of 30 asynchronous hours (no limit on virtual)

Further resources.

- [Getting an account with the Alliance](#)
- [Information on the Alliance's clusters](#)
 - Visit the page for the specific cluster to find its url
- Guide for [getting started on the cloud](#)
- [Information about the RAC process](#)
- The Alliance's [technical glossary](#)
- [Explora](#), the Alliance's training discovery portal



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada

Thank you!

Questions?

maria.finnsdottir@westdri.ca



Digital Research
Alliance of Canada

Alliance de recherche
numérique du Canada